

SJAA Ephemeris Bulletin

✱ April 2025

April Showers

As the saying goes, April showers bring May flowers. This month, April showers also bring *meteors* to our night skies in the form of the Lyrid meteor shower!

The Lyrid meteors are comet particles that are shed from the comet C/1861 G1 Thatcher. These meteors appear to radiate outwards from their namesake constellation, Lyra. Traveling at a speed of up to 29 miles per second, these bursts of light zip through the night sky pretty quickly, so be sure that you pick a dark spot and give your eyes about 30 minutes away from any bright lights to get fully dark-adapted. Bring some warm clothes, blankets and drinks and enjoy one of the oldest known meteor showers, first observed over 2,700 years ago.

April also brings plenty of great SJAA events, like Astro 101 talks and on-line Beginners' Forum, as well as ITSP, Starry Nights, and a Pinnacles Star Party! Keep looking up!

Carl Svensson
Vice-President
Ephemeris Editor

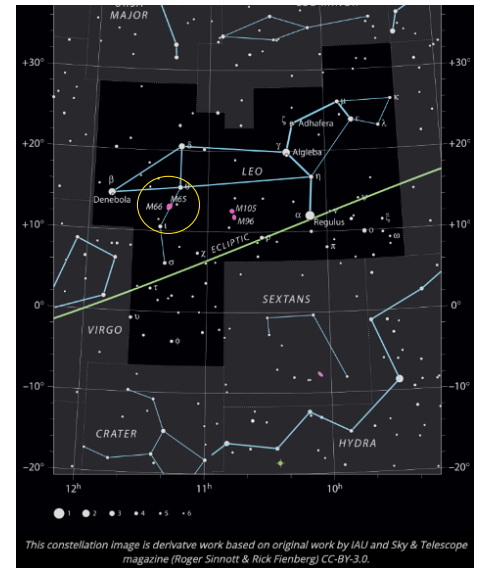
Target of the Month - Leo Triplet

by Joe Fragola

Messier 65 and Messier 66 were discovered by Charles Messier on March 1, 1780, and NGC 3628 was discovered by William Herschel on April 8, 1784. The three galaxies interact with one another, each having an affect on the structure of the neighboring galaxies. The disk of M65 appears slightly warped, and a recent burst of star formation also indicates possible external disturbance from the other two galaxies. M66 shows asymmetrical spiral arms and a core that appears to be off center. NGC 3628 has a tidal tail approximately 300,000 light years long. Due to its shape resembling a hamburger, NGC 3628 has been nicknamed the "Hamburger Galaxy".



The Leo Triplet. Image credit: Joe Fragola



Leo sky chart from theskylive.com.

Objects	M65	M66	NGC 3268
Magnitude	9.3	8.9	9.5
Diameter	117 kly	95 kly	140 kly
Object Type	Trio of Spiral Galaxies		
Constellation	Leo the Lion		
Distance	35 Million Light Years		
Age	12-13 Billion Years		

Volunteer Opportunities

There are many volunteer opportunities in SJAA! While we love having seasoned experts in our volunteer ranks, we happily welcome enthusiastic beginners, too. Please do not hesitate to reach out to the volunteer coordinator (volunteerchair@sjaa.net) to inquire about opportunities. Below are a few examples of programs that could use help:

Imaging SIG The SJAA Imaging SIG (Special Interest Group) welcomes members to give talks in our monthly imaging meetings on topics related to astro-imaging. World-class expertise not required! Example topics include: comet astrophotography, solar imaging, PixInsight skills, NINA tutorial, remote imaging, collimating telescopes, "my favorite astro gadgets", the science behind astrophotographs, "I love my mount/scope/software/...". Please don't be modest, we need you! For past talks see our YouTube channel. Please email imagingSIG@sjaa.net if you're interested.

Loaner Program Our loaner program is looking for one to two more volunteers to help members check out gear and to demonstrate the set-up and usage of loaned items.

Announcements

The results are in! Board and Officer elections have concluded, and here are the results. Larry Zurbrick, Ken Miura, Swami Nigam, Peter Melhus, and Marianne Damon ran for and were elected to the five open positions. Officers are: Larry Zurbrick as President, Carl Svensson as Vice President, Swami Nigam as Secretary, and Rob Jaworski as Treasurer.

The only requirement is an interest in astro gear and availability on one Sunday per month. Email loaners@sjaa.net if you are interested.

SSP The School Star Party Program is looking for more regular volunteers. We provide fun and exciting observing opportunities for schools. The ideal volunteer should have a telescope, some basic astronomy knowledge, and enjoy inspiring people. Interested parties should be available for the events and can contact ssp@sjaa.net for more information.



SJAA April 2025

Sunday	Monday	Tuesday	Wednesday	Thursday	Friday	Saturday
		1 Moon 0.6° N of the Pleiades  18%	2  28%	3 Gus Grissom's birthday (1926)  39%	4 Astro 101 Talk Online 7:00 PM First Quarter Moon  50%	5 Board Meeting 6:00 PM Guest Speaker 8:00 PM Mars 2° S of Moon  61%
6 FixIt 2:00 PM Loaner Exchange 2:00 PM Solar Sunday 2:00 PM  71%	7  80%	8 Astronomy Beginners' Forum 7:00 PM  88%	9  93%	10  97%	11  97%	12 Spica 0.3° N of Moon Full Moon  100%
13  100%	14  98%	15 Imaging SIG Meeting 7:30 PM  95%	16 Antares 0.4° N of Moon  90%	17  83%	18 Astro 101 Talk 7:30 PM In-Town Star Party 9:00 PM  75%	19 Starry Nights Star Party 9:00 PM  65%
20 Last Quarter Moon  55%	21  44%	22 Earth Day Lyrid Meteor Shower Peak Robert Oppenheimer's birthday (1904)  33%	23 Max Planck's birthday (1858)  23%	24 Saturn 2° S of Moon Venus 2° N of Moon  14%	25  6%	26 Mendoza Ranch Stargazing 7:20 PM Pinnacles Star Party 9:30 PM  2%
27 New Moon  0%	28 Jan Oort's Birthday (1900) Bart Bok's Birthday (1906) Eugene Shoemaker's Birthday (1928)  2%	29  7%	30  14%			
			Times and dates are subject to change. Please check sjaa.net and www.meetup.com/sj-astronomy for the latest updates.  Meteor Shower  Dark Sky Window			